

WORD FORMATTING AND SUBMISSION GUIDE

Course 261

Student Guideline

Clear structure • Consistent formatting • Reader-focused presentation

Assignment-specific instructions take precedence over this general guide.

1 Purpose and Audience

1.1 Purpose of the Guide

This guide explains how to prepare a clear, consistent, and professional Word document for Course 261. It applies to reports, analyses, reflections, and other written assignments. The guide uses numbered sections and subsections throughout and demonstrates the formatting practices it recommends.

The directions for a particular assignment always take precedence. When an assignment specifies a different margin, citation style, length, file type, or organizational structure, follow the assignment rather than this general guide.

1.2 Writing for the Reader

Before drafting, identify the intended reader and decide what that reader already knows.

Introduce the purpose or main claim early, explain necessary context, and arrange the evidence in an order that the reader can follow without reconstructing the argument.

Use direct sentences with clear subjects and strong verbs. Active voice is usually easier to read than passive voice, although passive constructions remain appropriate when the actor is unknown or unimportant. Revise vague references, unnecessary progressive forms, and informal filler. As practical checks, examine sentences that regularly extend beyond two full lines and paragraphs that regularly exceed about five sentences; these are signals to reconsider structure rather than absolute limits.

Use “that” for information essential to the meaning of a sentence and “which” for additional information set off by commas. Check spelling and grammar with Word Editor and at least one careful human reading. Names, numbers, citations, and technical terms require a separate accuracy check because automated tools may not identify an error that is grammatically valid.

1.3 Lead with the Answer

Organize the report around the reader’s question rather than the order in which the work was completed. A sequence such as data, cleaning, method, results, and interpretation records the

writer's effort, but it delays the information that the reader needs most. Open with the main finding, the most useful comparison, and any limitation essential to interpreting that finding.

Write the opening paragraph after completing the analysis, then move it to the beginning. A reader with limited time should be able to understand the answer from that paragraph; the rest of the report should show how the conclusion was reached and what qualifies it.

Table 1. Recommended sequence for a reader-centred report

Component	Purpose
Answer	State the main finding in plain language.
Question	Explain what was asked and why the answer matters.
Data	Identify the source, coverage, units, exclusions, and important gaps.
Method	Describe the calculation in ordinary language and provide enough detail for reproduction.
Results	Present the numbers, tables, and figures that support the answer.
Interpretation and limits	Explain what the result means and what the analysis cannot establish.
Sources	Provide enough information for another person to locate the data and supporting material.

Note: A short report may express each component in a paragraph; a longer report may use separate numbered sections.

2 Document Structure and Word Styles

2.1 Numbered Sections and Subsections

Apply Heading 1 to each major section, Heading 2 to each subsection, and Heading 3 only when a third level is genuinely necessary. Do not use a deeper hierarchy. The heading styles should be linked to one multilevel list so that Word creates numbers such as 2, 2.1, and 2.1.1 automatically.

Do not type section numbers manually. Automatic numbering remains correct when sections move, supports the Navigation Pane, and makes a table of contents possible when one is

required. Open View > Navigation Pane before submission and confirm that every heading appears at the correct level and in the correct order.

2.2 Paragraphs, Spacing, and Pasting

Use paragraph styles rather than repeated direct formatting. A formal report may use an unindented paragraph immediately after a heading, followed by paragraphs with a 0.5-inch first-line indent and no extra blank line between them. The exact convention matters less than applying one convention consistently throughout the document.

Do not press Enter repeatedly to create space before a heading or to move text to a new page. Control vertical space through the paragraph style, and use a page break when a new page is required. Apply “Keep with next” to headings so that a heading is not stranded at the bottom of a page.

When bringing text from another file or website, use Keep Text Only or Paste Special, then apply the appropriate style. This prevents imported fonts, spacing, numbering, and hidden style definitions from disrupting the document. Paste figures, equations, and tables separately and verify each object after pasting.

2.3 Page Layout and Word Section Breaks

A content section is created with a heading style; a Word section break is a layout control. Use section breaks only when part of the document requires a different orientation, header, footer, or page-numbering scheme. Do not insert a Word section break every time a new content section begins.

Unless the assignment states otherwise, use US Letter pages, portrait orientation, and 1-inch margins. Place a genuinely wide table or figure in its own landscape section, then return to portrait with a second section break. Number pages consistently and confirm that numbering continues correctly after every section break.

3 Presenting Quantitative Results

3.1 Precision, Units, and Comparisons

A calculated value is not automatically a useful reported number. Report only the precision that the measurement and decision can support. Keep full precision during intermediate calculations and round only for the final presentation. Extra decimal places imply accuracy that the data may not possess.

State units in the sentence, table heading, or axis label. A variable name alone rarely supplies enough information. In Excel, place the unit in the heading or use a custom number format rather than typing the unit into every cell, which converts numeric values to text.

Supply a comparison that helps answer the reader's question. When useful, report both the absolute difference and the relative difference, and identify the base used for a percentage. Appropriate comparisons may include another group, an earlier period, a target, or an established benchmark. Choose the comparison that best supports the decision.

3.2 Selectivity and Limitations

Report fewer numbers. Retain the values that advance the argument and move supporting detail to an appendix or separate data file. A long table is not a summary when the discussion uses only a few of its values. Complexity is not the goal; a direct comparison supported by traceable calculations is stronger than an elaborate presentation the reader cannot follow.

State limitations that could change the interpretation or action. Relevant limits may concern coverage, missing data, assumptions, differences between groups that the available data cannot separate, or an observed relationship that does not establish causation. Explain the consequence of each important limitation rather than relying on a general warning. Do not bury the answer beneath qualifications, but do not omit a limitation that could reverse the decision.

4 Figures

4.1 Content, Labelling, and Captions

Use a table when the reader needs exact values; use a figure when a comparison, pattern, or change matters more than the individual numbers. A figure should communicate one main point

without requiring the reader to search through the body text. If its purpose requires two unrelated explanations, it may be doing two jobs.

Introduce every figure before it appears. Name what it displays and tell the reader which feature supports the argument. This directs attention to the reason the figure is present rather than leaving the reader to decide what matters.

Give every figure a sequential number and an informative title. Label axes, units, series, categories, and panels clearly. When a figure contains more than one relationship or subplot, identify every component unambiguously. A useful caption identifies the measure, groups, time period, and units without repeating the full discussion in the preceding paragraph.

Place the figure number and title below the figure by using References > Insert Caption. Apply the Caption style, keep the caption with the figure, and add a note below the caption when the source, definitions, exclusions, or other interpretive details are required. Refer to every figure in the text with proper capitalization, such as “Figure 2 shows ...,” and insert the reference with References > Cross-reference rather than typing the number.

Figure 1 compares mean 2025 wheat yield across three soil zones. The black-zone mean is highest, and the brown-zone mean is lowest.

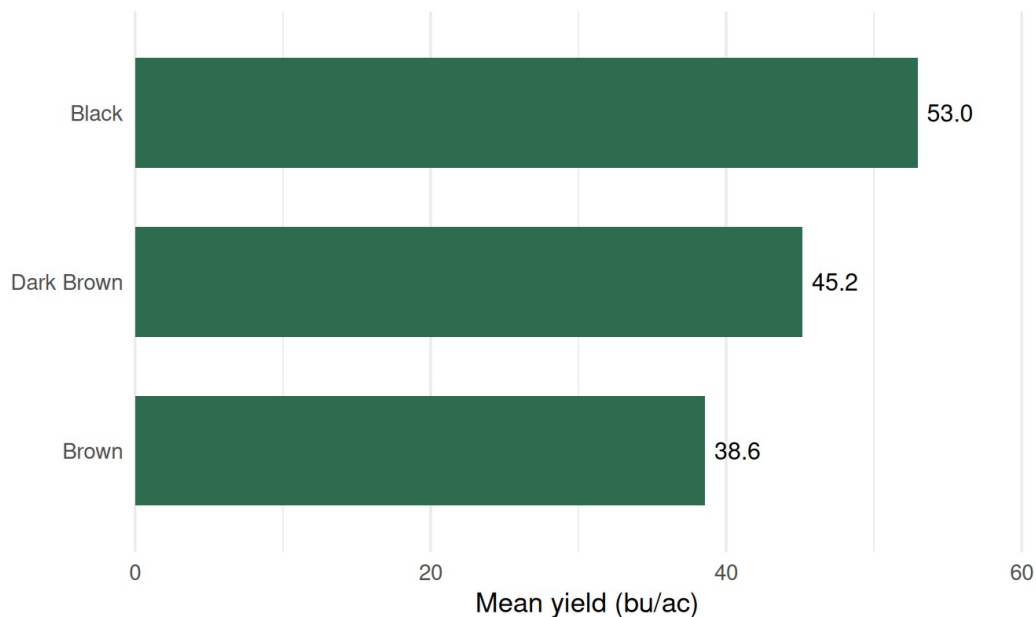


Figure 1. Mean wheat yield by soil zone, Saskatchewan synthetic field data, 2025

Note: Yields are in bushels per acre; four records with missing yield are excluded. Source: Agricultural Data Analytics, “Writing a Report.”

4.2 Quality, Consistency, and Placement

Use the same visual system across all figures: consistent fonts, label sizes, colours, line weights, backgrounds, and number formats. Do not rely on colour alone to distinguish information; combine colour with labels, markers, or line styles. Add concise alternative text through Picture Format > Alt Text.

Avoid screenshots of charts. Export or paste from the source program at high quality, using SVG or EMF for vector graphics when available and a suitably high-resolution PNG for raster images. Do not enlarge a small image, because scaling cannot restore missing detail.

Use In Line with Text when possible. Inline figures are more stable than floating figures when the document is edited or converted to PDF. Centre the figure between the margins and scale it so that all labels remain legible. If ordinary inline placement cannot keep a figure with its caption, a borderless one-cell table can provide a stable container, but it should be a last resort.

A linked Excel chart can be useful while editing, but a link may break when files move. Before submission, confirm that every linked or embedded chart displays correctly in both the Word file and the exported PDF. Build multi-panel figures as a deliberate grid, label panels (a), (b), and so on, and keep panel sizes and spacing consistent.

5 Tables

5.1 Titles, Labels, and Notes

Give every table a sequential number and a concise title that identifies its main focus. Place the number and title above the table with References > Insert Caption. Replace internal codes, programming variable names, and unexplained abbreviations with labels written for the reader. State units, symbols, definitions, and sources in a note below the table when they are not obvious.

Introduce every table before it appears, identify what it contains, and state which values support the discussion. Include only the rows and columns needed for the report. For a fixed summary range produced in Excel, Keep Source Formatting can preserve the designed table; Paste as Picture can freeze the appearance but will not update when the workbook changes. Do not retype calculated values into the report.

Table 2. Example of a clearly formatted table

Category	Group A	Group B	Unit
Measure 1	12.4	15.1	units
Measure 2	9.8	11.6	units
Measure 3	—	7.3	units

Note: Define units, symbols, and the data source when they are not obvious from the title and headings.

5.2 Alignment, Rules, and Pagination

Fit every table within the page margins without shrinking the text until it becomes difficult to read. Simplify a crowded table, divide it into logically distinct parts, or use a landscape section when width is unavoidable. Left-align columns that contain words and right-align columns that contain numbers, including their headings. A decimal tab may be preferable when decimal alignment is important.

Use restrained horizontal rules and whitespace instead of vertical lines or a heavy full grid. Single spacing is usually appropriate inside a table, provided that top and bottom cell margins leave sufficient breathing room. For a table that continues onto another page, select the header row and choose Table Layout > Repeat Header Rows. In Table Properties > Row, turn off “Allow row to break across pages” when splitting a row would harm readability.

Mention every table in the body before or near its location and use a cross-reference rather than a manually typed number. Do not insert the table itself in the middle of a sentence. Keep explanatory notes and source information directly below the table and distinguish those notes from ordinary document footnotes.

6 Equations and Symbols

6.1 Equation Formatting

Use Word’s built-in equation editor through Insert > Equation. Create subscripts, superscripts, fractions, and mathematical symbols in the equation editor rather than approximating them with ordinary text. Use the same mathematical formatting for a symbol when it appears in running text and in a displayed equation.

Place an important displayed equation on its own line. Number equations only when the text needs to refer to them, using sequential numbers at the right margin: (1), (2), and so on. Insert references with the cross-reference tool so that numbers remain correct after revisions.

Define every variable, subscript, superscript, and unit immediately before or after the equation. Treat the equation as part of the surrounding sentence and punctuate it accordingly. Do not end a paragraph or section with an equation that the text has not explained.

7 Methods, Sources, and Supporting Material

7.1 Describe the Method, Not the Keystrokes

Describe the calculation or procedure in ordinary language so that a knowledgeable reader can understand and reproduce it. State the data used, grouping or comparison, important transformations, exclusions, and treatment of missing values. Name software or functions only when that information helps reproduction or interpretation.

Do not turn the method section into a diary of menu choices, clicks, or code commands. Preserve formulas, scripts, workbook documentation, and labelled output ranges as the detailed record. The report should explain what was done and why; the supporting files should show exactly how it was implemented.

7.2 Citations and References

Use the citation style required by the assignment and apply it consistently to in-text citations and the reference list. A reference manager such as Zotero or Mendeley can help keep the two synchronized. Before submission, check both directions: every in-text citation should have a matching reference-list entry, and every reference-list entry should be cited unless the assignment asks for a broader bibliography.

Standardize author names, dates, titles, capitalization, publication information, page ranges, links, and DOIs. A reference manager reduces mechanical errors but does not replace verification of the imported metadata.

Related course resource: Agricultural Data Analytics, “Writing a Report,”
<https://agdataanalytics.com/module06b.html>.

7.3 Acknowledging Artificial Intelligence

Follow the course and assignment rules for artificial-intelligence tools. When acknowledgment is required, identify the tool, explain how it was used, and state what was independently checked or revised. Verify all AI-assisted text, data, analysis, and citations before submission.

7.4 Appendices and Computer Code

Use appendices only for supporting material that would interrupt the main discussion. Place them after the references, label them Appendix A, Appendix B, and so on, and refer to each appendix in the body. Treat each appendix as a section with its own descriptive title.

Present computer code as editable text in a dedicated Code style. Use a monospaced font such as Consolas or Courier New, single spacing, preserved indentation, and a light gray background or other restrained separation from the body text. Turn off spell checking for the Code style when appropriate. Avoid screenshots when editable code will work.

8 Final Review and Submission

8.1 Language and Field Checks

Complete a final language review with Word Editor and a careful human read-through. Check names, numbers, terminology, and citations separately. Select the entire document and update fields so that captions, cross-references, page numbers, and any generated content are current.

8.2 Layout and File Checks

Review the document in Print Layout view. Check page breaks, blank pages, headings, headers, footers, page numbers, tables, figures, equations, and the transition between portrait and landscape sections.

Unless an assignment explicitly requests another file type, submit the final document as a PDF. A PDF preserves margins, page breaks, figures, tables, and other formatting as intended. In Word, choose Print > Export as PDF, then open the exported file and inspect every page at a readable zoom, paying particular attention to symbols, graphics, captions, and page numbers.

Open the exact file that will be uploaded. Confirm the filename, file type, and required contents; verify that linked or embedded objects display correctly; and read the assignment

instructions one final time. Those instructions override this general guide whenever they specify a different requirement.

9 Submission Checklist

9.1 Document and Writing

- ☐ The document follows the assignment-specific instructions and uses numbered sections and subsections consistently.
- ☐ The opening states the main answer, a useful comparison, and any limitation essential to interpreting the finding.
- ☐ The purpose, intended reader, and organization are clear; sentences and paragraphs are direct and readable.
- ☐ Heading, body, caption, table-note, and code styles are applied consistently.
- ☐ Page numbers, margins, spacing, and Word section breaks have been checked in Print Layout view.

9.2 Figures, Tables, Equations, and Sources

- ☐ Reported numbers use meaningful units, comparisons, and no more precision than the data support.
- ☐ Every figure and table is numbered, titled, referenced in the text, and understandable on its own.
- ☐ Captions, labels, units, notes, sources, image quality, and alternative text are complete.
- ☐ Tables fit within the margins, align text and numbers appropriately, and paginate cleanly.
- ☐ Equations use Word's equation editor, consistent notation, suitable punctuation, and sequential numbering when needed.
- ☐ In-text citations and reference-list entries match and follow one consistent style.
- ☐ The method describes the analysis rather than software clicks, and important limitations are stated with their consequences.

9.3 Final File

- ☐ The final submission is a PDF unless the assignment explicitly requests another file type, and the exported PDF preserves the intended margins and formatting.
- ☐ AI use has been acknowledged when required, and all AI-assisted content has been verified.
- ☐ Captions, cross-references, page numbers, and other fields have been updated.
- ☐ Every page of the exported PDF has been reviewed, and the exact submission file opens correctly.

Final instruction. Read the assignment instructions once more before uploading. They take precedence over this general guide.